

Palau



Area 177 sq miles
(458 sq km)
Population 21,000
Capital Melekeok
Currency US dollar
Official languages Palauan
and English
Life expectancy 71 years



Palau lies in the western Pacific Ocean. It is made up of more than 300 islands in the Caroline Islands archipelago, only nine of which are inhabited. Palau is economically dependent on the US.



▲ GREEN SEA TURTLE

The ocean surrounding Palau is home to the green sea turtle. A threatened species, the turtle's population is closely monitored.

Kiribati



Area 277 sq miles
(717 sq km)
Population 102,000
Capital Bairiki
Currency Australian dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 65 years



Kiribati, formerly known as the Gilbert Islands, became independent from Britain in 1979. Britain's sole interest in Kiribati was its phosphate deposits, which ran out in 1980. The economy relies on the sale of fishing rights, copra exports, and money sent home by workers abroad. Kiribati is also heavily dependent on foreign aid.

Tuvalu



Area 10 sq miles
(26 sq km)
Population 10,600
Capital Fongafale
Currency Australian dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 69 years



Tuvalu is one of the world's smallest and most isolated nations. It was a British colony until it gained independence in 1978. Most Tuvaluans support themselves by farming and fishing. In a move to protect the environmentally fragile islands, Tuvalu plans to switch entirely to renewable sources of energy by 2020.

Samoa



Area 1,104 sq miles
(2,860 sq km)
Population 200,000
Capital Apia
Currency Tala
Official languages Samoan
and English
Life expectancy 71 years



Samoa, lying in the heart of the South Pacific, is made up of nine volcanic islands. Only four of these islands are inhabited—Apolima, Manono, Savai'i, and Upolu. Ethnically, 91 percent of the Samoan population is Polynesian. An additional 8 percent is Euronesian (of mixed European/Polynesian descent).

Solomon Islands



Area 10,985 sq miles
(28,450 sq km)
Population 600,000
Capital Honiara
Currency Solomon
Islands dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 63 years



The Solomons archipelago has several hundred islands, but most people live on the six largest—Guadalcanal, Malaita, New Georgia, Makira, Santa Isabel, and Choiseul. The Solomon Islands, most of which are coral reefs, draw many tourists, especially for deep-sea diving. The islands are rich in copra and minerals such as gold.

Nauru



Area 8.1 sq miles
(21 sq km)
Population 9,400
Capital Yaren
Currency Australian dollar
Official language Nauruan
Life expectancy 64 years



The world's smallest republic, Nauru lies in the Pacific Ocean. Once a British colony, it became independent in 1968. Its main revenue has been from phosphate reserves, which are now dwindling. Mining activities have destroyed 80 percent of its ecosystem.

Tonga



Area 289 sq miles
(748 sq km)
Population 106,200
Capital Nuku'alofa
Currency Pa'anga
Official languages English
and Tongan
Life expectancy 73 years



Located in the South Pacific, the Kingdom of Tonga is an archipelago of 170 islands. These are divided into three main groups, Vava'u, Ha'apai, and Tongatapu. Tonga's eastern islands are low and fertile, while those in the west are higher and volcanic in origin. Tonga's economy is based on farming, especially vanilla and squash production.



▲ LEAF FROG

Varying in color from gold to brown to green, this species lives in the tropical rainforests of the Solomon Islands. It is also known as the eyelash frog because of the projections over its eyes.